

A traditional burial can start at around \$5,000, but with all the extras, you could easily end up spending \$15,000—the great irony being, of course, that the person you are spending that money on won't be there to appreciate it.

Funeral directors make their livings off of the bereaved. Remember: they're salespeople. Beware of phrases like "I know you want what's best for your father," and "This is the last thing you can do to honor your mother." You want another piece of advice? Don't do an open casket. You pay a premium for them, but they don't honor your loved one's death or life.

Now let's talk about the casket itself. Here's a little-known secret: you can buy caskets online from Walmart or Costco that are just as nice as the ones in the showroom and cost thousands less. Those who are environmentally conscious can even choose a rental casket, a thick cardboard container that is removed before burial or cremation. If there are no low-cost caskets in the display room of the funeral home, ask to see one anyway. Believe it or not, some places hide them in the basement—out of sight, out of mind.

Deciding between cremation and burial can be a difficult and painful decision. Only you know what's right for your family; all I can do is provide some financial facts. As a general rule, the cost of cremation is one-quarter that of a burial. Simple cremations start around \$600, though if you get all the extras—the obituary notice, the viewing—it can cost up to \$4,500. Cremation costs vary by province; a low-cost cremation can be obtained for \$587 in Quebec, \$995 in Vancouver and \$1,400 in Toronto. In certain provinces, the cost is higher—in New Brunswick, for example, a simple cremation can cost close to \$3,000. It's considered morbid to discuss a funeral, let alone plan for one. *But you must have these conversations now.* Open the discussion with your parents and with your partner.

Also, decide on a course of action if one of you were to have a serious accident or contract a debilitating illness. Discuss your feelings about a DNR (do not resuscitate) order. If we are honest with ourselves, most of us would never want a loved one to keep us hooked up to a machine if we were brain-dead, draining our loved one emotionally and financially. But if you don't let your feelings be